least two metres to clear the paving around the pool. We executed simple 'bommies' most of the time, but some of my friends used to try somersaults as well. Looking back, it's difficult to understand how nobody ever hit their head on the side of the pool and suffered a serious injury.

My mother understood the risks all too well and unequivocally banned the game, which of course made it even more exciting to me and my friends.

'Is your mom home this afternoon?'

'She may be going out later. Why?'

'Well, maybe we can come round and play in the pool.'

So they would come to 20 Mentz Avenue and we would awkwardly hang around until my mother left the house, and then we would rush out, climb up onto the roof and start our forbidden games.

As a sports-mad youngster, this was an ideal environment. I could not have wished for anything more.

For facilities, beyond our adventure playground of a house, there was the Warmbaths Sports Club, where the De Villiers family would spend most Saturday mornings, playing golf or tennis, socialising. Everybody seemed to know everybody and, aged five or six, I was left to wander around as I liked, maybe hitting a few golf balls or finding an empty tennis court and playing with anyone who happened to be around.

For opposition, there were always my elder brothers.

Jan and Wessels always set the benchmark.

Both were talented sportsmen who played hard and generally fair, who pushed me to the limit and occasionally beyond, who treated me as an equal, who let me play with, who always found time to teach me how to play whatever they played, how to hold a bat, how to field, how to swing the ball, how to spin the ball, even how to oil my bat … and who, whatever happened, all these years unequivocally supported and loved me.

For so many years, growing up in their shadows, I lived in a constant state of over-excitement, forever looking forward to the next game with